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constituent of the Hurriyat Conference and supported calls for boycott of elections post 1987. But though it stayed away from the electoral process, the influential organisation was accused of being a linchpin of the PDP, tacitly supporting the party in the previous elections. That was partly due to its decades-old political rivalry with the NC, particularly for its alleged rigging of the 1987 election to defeat the Muslim United Front (MUF), a grouping of several conservative parties, including the Jamaat. A majority of these parties became part of the Hurriyat Conference in the spring of 1993.

Thirty-seven years later, the BJP is trying to rectify the mistakes of the past by allowing separatists to run for elections while keeping up pressure on the Jamaat by not lifting the ban on it. The participation of separatist leaders has helped remove fear in the vast network of rural and urban Kashmir, allowing political parties to venture into restricted areas in south and north Kashmir or Srinagar's volatile downtown. Hence the daily door-to-door campaigns, roadshows and poll rallies all around without fear of reprisal from militants or separatists.

J&K SAW A RECORD TURNOUT OF 58.4% IN THE LS POLL IN MAY, A 30 % PT JUMP FROM 2019. THE ASSEMBLY VOTING IN JUST PHASE 1 ON SEPT. 18 HAS EXCEEDED THAT

THE IDENTITY QUESTION

While the BJP counts the abrogation of Article 370 among its greatest achievements, the party's opponents like the NC, PDP as well as its former ally, the Sajad Lone-led PC, are unanimous about restoring J&K's special status. The NC manifesto, titled 'Dignity, Identity and Development', released by Omar Abdullah in Srinagar on August 19, promised to strive for restoring the erstwhile state to pre-August 2019 status. However, against his vow of not contesting the election in the Union Territory, Omar is now contesting from two seats, Budgam and Ganderbal, his family's traditional bastion. In Ganderbal, where three generations of Abdullahs have contested, Omar sees New Delhi's hand in fielding jailed people against him. "The BJP does not like this," he said at a rally here on September 6. "This is why conspiracy after conspiracy is being hatched against me. But this conspiracy has succeeded only once. This time I have full faith in the people of Ganderbal that they will vote wisely." The NC has tied up with the Congress to bolster its chances of winning seats in Jammu and denting the BJP's tally there.